

Essential Resourcing: Final Need to Complete and Launch

Hard launch checklist based on live Railway deployment checks on 3 July 2026.

The blunt verdict

Decision update: Resend/email delivery is deliberately deferred until David is ready to make email DNS/domain changes. The website domain cutover is still parked as the final step.

The website is deployed and working on Railway. It is not ready for final public launch on the live domain until the launch blockers below are completed.

Ruthless summary: the build is strong; the remaining risk is not design or code. It is production account setup: email delivery, analytics/consent, booking, final DNS/domain cutover and legal/privacy sign-off.

Railway hosting: PASS. Live deployment SUCCESS on service web, commit fa02e0f. Railway preview URL returns 200.

Public pages: PASS. 41 live URLs checked on Railway, including 26 sitemap URLs. Zero broken responses found.

CMS access: PASS. CMS gate accepts credentials, sets the session cookie and opens /studio with 200 after login.

Sanity content: PASS. Production dataset sle6d8y3 / production contains 41 documents: homepage, site settings, services, jobs, insights, case studies, salary snapshots, navigation and person record.

WhatsApp direct contact: PASS. NEXT_PUBLIC_WHATSAPP_NUMBER is set to David's WhatsApp number. Live homepage exposes WhatsApp links.

Email delivery: BLOCKER. RESEND_API_KEY is intentionally missing. Two supplied keys were tested and Resend returned "API key is invalid". David has chosen to defer Resend until he is ready for domain/DNS email setup. Contact form validates but cannot send real email until a fresh valid key is connected.

Booking link: BLOCKER. NEXT_PUBLIC_GOOGLE_BOOKING_URL is missing. Booking page falls back to contact/WhatsApp.

Analytics: BLOCKER. No GA4 or GTM ID is set. There is no duplicate analytics risk right now, but analytics launch is not complete.

Consent/legal: BLOCKER. Privacy and cookie pages exist with legal-review warnings. Final wording still needs review before public launch.

Live domain cutover: BLOCKER BY CHOICE. DNS/custom domain switch has not been done because David asked to leave www.essentialresourcing.co.uk as the final step.

What is live right now

- Hosted preview URL: <https://web-production-ba3b9.up.railway.app/>
- Railway project: essential-resourcing, project ID 556ea44e-18cc-445f-bf56-928457a60a0a.
- Railway service: web, deployed from GitHub repo dwalsh8716-collab/Jobstodoincodex, branch codex/recreate-homepage-handoff.
- Current deployed commit checked: fa02e0f.
- The in-app browser has been opened on the live Railway URL, not the local preview.
- Custom live domain cutover has intentionally not been completed yet.

Verified checks completed

- Railway latest deployment status: SUCCESS.
- Homepage returned HTTP 200 from Railway.
- /api/health returned HTTP 200.
- /cms returned HTTP 200.
- /studio redirects to /cms when not logged in, then opens after CMS login.
- /robots.txt, /sitemap.xml, /rss.xml, /llms.txt and /llms-full.txt returned HTTP 200.
- CMS login sets essential_cms_session and redirects to /studio correctly on Railway.
- Sanity production dataset has 41 documents and the expected core content types.
- Live public route crawl checked 41 URLs with no failed responses.
- Contact API rejects bad submissions safely.
- Contact API accepts a valid smoke-test enquiry but reports that email delivery still needs configuring when no valid Resend key is present.
- Homepage contains WhatsApp contact links for David's WhatsApp number.
- No GA4/GTM scripts were found on the live page because no GA/GTM ID is set. That avoids accidental duplicate tracking, but it means analytics is not launched.

Launch blockers David must finish

1. Connect Resend for real enquiry email delivery

Status: BLOCKER / DEFERRED BY CHOICE. The form validates on Railway, but real email sending is not live because RESEND_API_KEY is intentionally missing until David is ready for Resend/domain email setup.

Evidence: two supplied Resend keys were tested on 3 July 2026. Resend returned "API key is invalid" both times. A fresh valid production key is still required from the correct Resend account/project. Resend domain verification does not have to switch the website to Railway, but it normally requires DNS records, so it is parked until David is ready to make email DNS changes.

What David needs to do:

- Log in to Resend and open the correct workspace/project for Essential Resourcing New Build 2026.

- Add or verify essentialresourcing.co.uk as a sending domain when David is ready to make email DNS changes.
- Add the DNS records Resend gives you at the domain provider. Verification can be quick, but DNS can take up to 72 hours.
- Create a fresh production API key. Do not paste it into chat. Put it directly into Railway if possible.
- Add the key in Railway as RESEND_API_KEY on the web service.
- Keep CONTACT_TO_EMAIL set to david@essentialresourcing.co.uk.
- Keep CONTACT_FROM_EMAIL set to a Resend-verified sender such as website@essentialresourcing.co.uk.
- Redeploy Railway and send a real contact-form test. Confirm the email lands in David's inbox.

Exact Railway variables needed:

- RESEND_API_KEY = private Resend API key, normally starting with re_, only after the domain/sender is ready
- CONTACT_TO_EMAIL = david@essentialresourcing.co.uk
- CONTACT_FROM_EMAIL = website@essentialresourcing.co.uk, only if that sender/domain is verified in Resend

No faff: if the form cannot send email, the site is not commercially launch-ready.

2. Add the booking link

Status: BLOCKER if booking is intended for launch. The website has a booking page and fallback copy, but the actual Google booking URL is not set.

- Create a Google Calendar appointment schedule for David.
- Copy the public booking page URL.
- Add it to Railway as NEXT_PUBLIC_GOOGLE_BOOKING_URL.
- Redeploy and test /book-a-call from desktop and mobile.

3. Choose GA4 or GTM, not both messily

Status: BLOCKER for measurement. No GA4 or GTM ID is currently set, so there is no duplicate analytics risk right now. But launch analytics is not live.

Recommendation: use GTM only if David wants one container for GA4 plus future tags. Use direct GA4 if he wants the simplest possible setup. Do not set both unless GTM is configured not to duplicate pageviews.

- Option A: NEXT_PUBLIC_GA_ID = G-XXXXXXXXXX
- Option B: NEXT_PUBLIC_GTM_ID = GTM-XXXXXXX

Consent warning: analytics should not be considered properly launch-ready for UK/EEA traffic until the cookie banner/CMP and Google Consent Mode V2 flow are reviewed and tested. Google Consent Mode is not a cookie banner by itself.

4. Legal/privacy review before public launch

Status: BLOCKER. Privacy Policy, Cookie Policy and candidate/privacy handling pages exist, but they are marked for legal review. That is correct. It must not be hand-waved away.

- Review Privacy Policy and Cookie Policy with a proper legal/privacy reviewer.
- Confirm wording for GA4/GTM, WhatsApp, LinkedIn, Resend/email handling, contact forms and candidate/job data.
- Confirm cookie categories and consent banner wording before enabling tracking.
- Do not call the site legally compliant until this is done.

5. Final live-domain cutover

Status: intentionally not done yet. David asked not to switch www.essentialresourcing.co.uk until the end.

- Once Resend, booking, analytics/consent and legal review are complete, add essentialresourcing.co.uk and www.essentialresourcing.co.uk to Railway domains.
- Update DNS at the domain provider to point to Railway.
- Wait for SSL/domain status to become healthy in Railway.
- Retest homepage, services, contact form, CMS login, sitemap, robots, WhatsApp and analytics on the final domain.
- Only then switch Search Console and GA4 validation to the final live-domain checks.

Important but not launch blockers

- Database: DATABASE_URL and OPERATIONS_DB_ENABLED are not set. That is acceptable for a brochure/content-led launch if enquiries are handled by email. It is required only if David wants database-backed private operations, audit logs, candidate/client portal workflows or stored enquiries.
- WhatsApp Business API: direct WhatsApp links are live. Automated WhatsApp Business outbound confirmations are not enabled because Meta WhatsApp API credentials are not set. That is not needed for launch unless David wants automated WhatsApp messages.
- Google Cloud CLI: installed and signed in as david@essentialresourcing.co.uk. It is not the website host. Railway is hosting the website; Sanity is the CMS.
- Untracked local QA/helper files exist in the workspace. They are not deployed because Railway deploys from the pushed GitHub branch. Clean them later so the workspace stays tidy.

Production environment variables

NEXT_PUBLIC_SITE_URL: Set. Currently set to <https://essentialresourcing.co.uk> as requested. Final domain is not cut over yet.

Sanity variables: Set. NEXT_PUBLIC_SANITY_PROJECT_ID, dataset and API version are present. Server-side Sanity variables are also present.

NEXT_PUBLIC_WHATSAPP_NUMBER: Set. David's WhatsApp number is configured.

NEXT_PUBLIC_WHATSAPP_DEFAULT_MESSAGE: Set. Default WhatsApp message is configured.

NEXT_PUBLIC_LINKEDIN_URL: Set. David's LinkedIn URL is configured.

GOOGLE_SITE_VERIFICATION: Set. Search Console token is present. Verify again after final DNS cutover.

CONTACT_TO_EMAIL: Set. david@essentialresourcing.co.uk.

CONTACT_FROM_EMAIL: Set. website@essentialresourcing.co.uk, but it must be verified in Resend before production sending.

RESEND_API_KEY: Missing. Deferred by choice until Resend/domain email setup is ready. Fresh valid key required; supplied keys were invalid.

CMS gate variables: Set. CMS gate works on Railway. Do not reveal these values.

NEXT_PUBLIC_GOOGLE_BOOKING_URL: Missing. Booking CTA falls back until this is added.

NEXT_PUBLIC_GA_ID / NEXT_PUBLIC_GTM_ID: Missing. Choose one analytics route. Avoid duplicate pageviews.

DATABASE_URL / OPERATIONS_DB_ENABLED: Missing. Only needed for database-backed private operations.

NODE_VERSION / NIXPACKS_NODE_VERSION: Set. Node 24 configured for Railway/Sanity 6 compatibility.

Resend connection: exact safe path

Use this sequence. It avoids leaking the key and avoids a false "email is done" claim.

- Open Resend and select Essential Resourcing New Build 2026.
- Domains: add or open essentialresourcing.co.uk.
- DNS: add every record Resend provides. This usually includes DKIM and may require SPF/DMARC alignment depending on the domain setup.
- Wait until Resend marks the domain as verified.
- API Keys: create a fresh production sending key named Railway Essential Resourcing Production.
- In Railway, open essential-resourcing > web > Variables and add RESEND_API_KEY. Paste the key there, not in GitHub and not in chat.
- Redeploy Railway.
- Submit the live contact form with a real test message.
- Confirm David receives the email, the user-facing success message is clean, and no secrets appear in logs.

Official Resend setup references used: <https://resend.com/docs/add-a-domain>, <https://resend.com/docs/create-an-api-key>, <https://resend.com/docs/send-with-nodejs>, <https://resend.com/docs/knowledge-base/how-to-handle-api-keys>

Final go-live sequence

- When David is ready for email DNS setup, connect and test Resend. Leads are money, but do not use invalid keys or fake delivery.
- Add the Google booking link and test it from the booking page and homepage CTAs.
- Choose GA4 or GTM. Add only one route, then test with consent mode/CMP behaviour.
- Complete privacy/cookie/legal review and update final wording where needed.
- Add Railway custom domains and update DNS.
- Retest the final live domain: home, services, contact, jobs, CMS, sitemap, robots, WhatsApp, booking, analytics and Search Console verification.
- Submit the final sitemap in Search Console.
- Do a real mobile test: WhatsApp, contact form, booking, hamburger menu and CMS login.
- Only after the above, call it launched.

Commands already run and passed

- npm run typecheck passed.
- npm run lint passed.
- npm run test passed: 59 test files, 351 tests.
- npm run build passed locally.
- Railway production build passed and deployed successfully.
- Live Railway public crawl passed with zero failed URLs.

Ruthless engineering view

Do not rebuild the site. Do not redesign it again before launch. The best move now is operational discipline: connect the missing production accounts, test the real workflows, then cut over the domain.

The site is good enough to deploy. It is not good enough to launch publicly until Resend, booking, analytics/consent, legal review and DNS cutover are finished.

No fake compliance. No fake email delivery. No duplicate tags. No last-minute palette drift. Finish the real launch plumbing and ship it properly.